

THE CONTRACT DECODER

11 Contract Clauses That Are Costing You
Thousands

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WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

Part 1: The 5 Contract Danger Zones

Part 2: 11 Contract Clauses Decoded

Part 3: The 7-Step Contract Audit Method

Part 4: Negotiation Scripts That Work

Part 5: Real Case Studies & Savings

DANGER ZONE 1: The Scope of Work

When a contract says "standard materials" or "customary installation" those words mean NOTHING legally. They give the contractor permission to decide what is included, and you pay for it.

EXAMPLE: A \$45,000 kitchen renovation with "cabinetry as selected." The contractor chose builder-grade. Upgrades cost \$8,400 extra.

FIX: Every material by brand, model, quantity, and price. If it is not in the contract, it is not included.

DANGER ZONE 2: The Payment Schedule

Contracts demanding 50-70% upfront = zero leverage.

A \$75,000 project with 60% down = \$45,000 before work starts.

If they stop after framing, you lost \$45,000.

FIX: Max 25-30% deposit. Milestone payments. 20% held to end.

DANGER ZONE 3: Change Order Clause

Unlimited markups on changes = blank check.

A bathroom reno went from \$18,000 to \$31,000
because the contractor charged 45% on every change.

FIX: Cap markups at 10-12%. Written approval required.

DANGER 4: Fine Print Appendices

The worst terms are in exhibits you never see.

Hidden: arbitration, liability caps, venue selection.

DANGER 5: Auto-Renewal Trap

Missed a 90-day window by 12 days.

Locked into \$400/month for another year. \$4,800 wasted.

11 CONTRACT CLAUSES DECODED

01: Time is of the Essence - If YOU delay, you breach.

02: Force Majeure - Some define it to excuse supplier delays.

03: Indemnification - You could pay their legal costs.

04: Limitation of Liability - Caps at contract value.

05: Waiver of Consequential Damages - No indirect loss recovery.

06: Attorney Fees - Losing means paying their bills.

07: Arbitration - You give up right to sue and jury trial.

08: Governing Law - May force you to sue in their state.

09: Entire Agreement - Verbal promises are meaningless.

10: Assignment - Your contract sold without consent.

11: Right to Lien - Protects them, can be abused.

7-STEP CONTRACT AUDIT METHOD

Step 1: Map the Money

Step 2: Trace Payment Schedule

Step 3: Find Change Order Language

Step 4: Read the Fine Print

Step 5: Check Auto-Renewal

Step 6: Verify Scope Completeness

Step 7: Use AI at hiddenfeeai.com - \$15

NEGOTIATION SCRIPTS

Script 1: "This markup is above standard. Can you break it down?"

Script 2: "I prefer milestone payments with 20% held to completion."

Script 3: "Cap change orders at 12% with my written approval."

Script 4: "Remove auto-renewal, make it month-to-month."

REAL CASE STUDIES

HVAC: \$14.5k proposal to \$10.8k. Saved \$3,200.

Auto Loan: 2.5% APR markup. Saved \$2,400.

Renovation: 35% material markup. Saved \$12,000+.

Medical: \$12k ER bill to \$4,200. Saved \$7,800.

YOUR ACTION PLAN

1. Get scope in writing with brand, model, quantity
2. Negotiate max 30% down, milestone-based
3. Cap change orders at 10-12% with approval
4. Read every appendix before signing
5. Remove auto-renewal or set reminders
6. Upload to hiddenfeeai.com for \$15

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